How to mix the colour and its shades

In painting yellow is one of the basic colours. **It is easiest to start with yellow from the tube** and look for the form you want to give it. From red and blue alone you cannot mix a pure yellow. The proportions are approximate, every brand behaves a little differently, so **try them out on paper first**.

What to prepare

Lemon yellow
Cooler, sometimes with a slight lean towards green.

Warm yellow
Closer to the sun, egg yolk and orange.

Yellow ochre
An earthy pigment that is already more muted in itself.

White
For light and gentler shades.

Red or orange
For warmer yellows.

Earthy brown
For earthy, mustard and honey mixes.

Blue
Added very carefully, because it quickly pushes yellow towards green.

How can you recognise it without technical names?

Put several yellow samples side by side.

Lemon can recall the peel of a lemon. **Sunflower** tends to be warmer and fuller. **Butter** is light and soft. **Mustard** is more muted, with a brownish or greenish tint. **Ochre** already strongly recalls soil.

Names on tubes are not a uniform recipe. “Sun yellow” from one maker can look different from another's. A small sample helps, and next to it the same colour mixed with white. A touch of white often shows the undertone that you can easily overlook in thick paint.

On some tubes you will find the mark PY and a number, that is, the designation of a yellow pigment. Two colours with a similar name do not have to contain the same pigment.

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What the additions do



White

Lightens it and shifts it towards butter and vanilla. Add it a little at a time, yellow easily gets lost under a stronger pigment.

→



Orange

Warms. Sunflower and golden yellow.

→ 



Red

Leads to warmer, darker yellows. A strong pigment, add it carefully.

→ 



Ochre

An earthy pigment that mutes yellow. Golden, sandy.

→ 



Brown

For earthy, mustard and honey mixes. It can take command very quickly.

→ 



Blue

Pushes yellow towards yellow-green. Add it on the tip of the brush.

→ 



Violet

Its opposite on the colour wheel. A drop (roughly 1 part to 20 parts yellow) calms it into a grey-yellow.

→ 

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Ten yellows to try

A part means an equally large portion of paint, a drop or a heap. Take the proportions as the start of an experiment. Every colour from a tube has a different strength; brown, red and blue in particular can take command very quickly.

Soft lemon



4 parts white + 1 part lemon yellow. Light, fresh, spring-like.

Butter



5 parts white + 1 part warm yellow. Soft, kind.

Vanilla



8 parts white + 1 part warm yellow + a tiny trace of ochre. Quiet, creamy.

Sunflower



10 parts warm yellow + 1 part orange. Rich, warming. The proportion is my approximate suggestion, adjust it by the orange from the tube.

Golden yellow



4 parts warm yellow + a trace of orange and brown. Festive, warm.

Honey



3 parts warm yellow + a small amount of ochre and brown. Thick, kind.

Mustard



3 parts yellow + brown added gradually; possibly a little white. Earthy, retro.

Earthy ochre mix



3 parts yellow + 1 part earthy brown; adjust with white. Clay, caves. The proportion is my approximate suggestion.

Sand



6 parts white + 1 part ochre; a little yellow if needed. Calm, natural.

Yellow-green



4 parts lemon yellow + the very tip of blue. Fresh, sour, approaching green.

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